

BIRKEN LAKESIDE RESORT • SINCE 1906

THE LOCAL GUIDE.

Woodsmoke. Pristine water. Good people.

A GUEST GUIDE FOR YOUR STAY
2026 SEASON

BIRKEN LAKESIDE RESORT

SINCE 1906 · GATES LAKE, BC

FOR YOUR STAY

The Local Guide

What to do, where to go, and what we'd send a friend to.

You came here for the lake. We understand. But you've also got the rest of the Sea-to-Sky right outside the cabin door — old-growth forest, turquoise glacier lakes, farms that grew the beer you're about to drink, and roads that end at water.

This is the local guide we'd write for a friend who just landed. Everything here is within an hour of the dock. We've tried it. We've sent people. We'd go again.

Woodsmoke. Pristine water. Good people.

BEFORE YOU GO ANYWHERE

Three honest notes

First, the famous places are famous for a reason — and they're busy because of it. We'll tell you when something is worth the crowd and when it isn't. Joffre is stunning. Joffre is also a parking lot. Both are true.

Second, the quiet places are quiet because nobody talks about them. We're talking about them in this document. Please don't put them on TikTok.

Third, when in doubt, ask the host on duty. They know the trail conditions, the wildlife sightings this week, and which farm-gate shop has strawberries today.

PART ONE

The lake

The reason you came. The reason you'll come back.

Gates Lake

Slow mornings. Glassy water. Mountain shadows that move across the surface like they're keeping time. Loons at dusk. The kind of quiet that has weight to it.

The dock is yours while you're here. So is the lake. Swim in it, paddle on it, fish from it, or sit beside it and do nothing for an entire afternoon. The water is part of the deal — there's a kind of clarity that comes from being briefly, completely awake.

The water	Cold. Clear. Bring a towel.
What's in there	Rainbow Trout, Cutthroat Trout, Bull Trout. The big ones run to 6.5 lbs.
What we have	Kayaks, paddleboards, and a dock that gets used.
The history	Birken sat on the Harrison-Lillooet Gold Rush Trail. The lake watched the whole thing happen.

Up the road

D'Arcy, fifteen minutes north. Where the highway runs out.

Drive north from the cabins and the road gets quieter, rougher, and more interesting fast. D'Arcy — once called Port Anderson — is where the road literally ends and Anderson Lake begins. It's a worthwhile half-day on its own.

Heritage Beach

The tip of Anderson Lake. A swim, a picnic, a slow hour with a book. The lowest-effort, highest-reward stop in the corridor.

McGillivray Falls

Down the rail line from D'Arcy. Worth knowing before you go: this place holds a heavy history as a WWII relocation centre for Japanese-Canadians. The remnants of the old resort are still there,

and the quiet of the valley still says something. It's not a tourist stop — it's a place that deserves the visit and the silence.

The Highline Road

A legendary 4x4 shelf road that hugs the cliffs above Anderson Lake on the way to Seton Portage. Narrow, steep, and the most dramatic views in the corridor.

GOOD TO KNOW

This is not a road for a rental sedan. You'll need real ground clearance, four-wheel drive, and a driver who's comfortable with exposure. If any of those are in question, Heritage Beach is the better day.

PART TWO

The headline parks

Three names you'll hear. Here's the honest read on each.

Birkenhead Lake Provincial Park

Twenty minutes from the cabin. Our pick.

Old-growth forest, sandy beaches, water so clear you can see the bottom from the shore. It's everything you came here for, doubled. The big park that doesn't feel like a tourist site.

Two trails worth the walk: the 8 km Birkenhead Lake Trail, flat and easy on foot or bike — perfect for a slow afternoon — and the 1 km Goat Lookout, a steep climb out of the campground that earns you a bird's-eye view of the whole valley.

Mountain goats, osprey, the occasional black bear. Standard wilderness manners apply: don't feed anything, don't approach anything, and give wildlife room.

Joffre Lakes Provincial Park

Thirty minutes south. The famous one. Beautiful, and a zoo.

Three glacier-fed lakes the colour of a postcard. The hike is a serious 10 km round trip with real elevation. The views are genuinely stunning — we just can't pretend the crowds aren't part of the experience now.

GOOD TO KNOW

BC Parks now requires day-use passes for Joffre, booked in advance through their website. Check this before you leave the cabin — the gate will turn you around if you don't have one.

Our suggestion: if you're going, leave the cabin before sunrise. Or skip Joffre entirely and spend the day at Birkenhead. We'd take Birkenhead. You can hear yourself think.

Birkenhead Peak

The big one. Ten hours up and back. For the people who came for this.

A serious mountaineering hike with a 360-degree payoff at the top — the Coast Mountains in every direction. This is not a casual walk. It's an alpine route that demands experience, the right gear, and a four-wheel-drive to even reach the trailhead.

GOOD TO KNOW

If you've done routes like this before and you have the right kit, it's an unforgettable day. If you haven't, we love that you're curious — and we'd point you to the Goat Lookout trail instead, which gives you the view without the day-long commitment.

PART THREE

If you're here to fish

Three lakes. Three personalities. Match the kit to the water.

Gates Lake is right outside the cabin. Birkenhead is twenty minutes. Anderson is half an hour. Three very different fisheries, and all of them are worth a morning.

Gates Lake

Our home water. Resident Rainbow and Cutthroat trout, some of them substantial — six pounds and change is not unheard of. The fish here are well-fed and picky, which is the polite way of saying you'll need the right pattern. In spring (May and June), midges work — chironomid patterns in olive or black. By summer, the trout drop deep to stay cool, and you'll have better luck with leech patterns near structure, or dragonfly nymph imitations near the lily pads.

Birkenhead Lake

Bigger water, less-fished, and a real chance at a memorable catch. If Gates feels too quiet, Birkenhead usually delivers. The campground end has the easiest shore access.

Anderson Lake

The serious answer. Anderson is for trolling, and it holds Dolly Varden and Bull Trout that can run large. The drive up to D'Arcy is part of the day — bring lunch, take your time.

The 2026 sockeye run

2026 is a dominant sockeye year on the Fraser. Late August through early September, millions of fish return to the Fraser system to spawn. Sockeye don't run through Gates Lake itself, but the broader corridor sees a lot of interest — if salmon viewing is the plan, ask a host where to point you.

PART FOUR

Pemberton

Twenty-five minutes south. Mountain bikes, farms, and the best burger within an hour.

Mountain biking

Pemberton has a world-class trail network. The terrain runs from soft family loops to genuinely terrifying expert descents, sometimes connected by the same climb. Three rides we'd actually send you on:

If you're starting out, or riding with the family

Park at One Mile Lake. Ride the One Mile Lake Loop for a flat warm-up with views, then climb Happy Trail — which has a reputation as one of the best climbing trails in BC — and roll back down on Piece of Cake. It's a soft introduction to what Pemberton riding feels like.

If you've got intermediate legs and want the view

Climb Nimby, the legendary switchback that locals love and tourists curse halfway up. At the top, take Rudy's — a trail built in memory of a local pilot — for a flowing descent with valley vistas the whole way down.

If you came for the famous Pemby tech

Overnight Sensation or Cream Puff. Rocky, steep, dusty. Real black-diamond riding. If you know what you're doing, you already know these names.

Where to eat

The Beer Farmers (Pemberton Meadows)

Fourth-generation farm growing the hops and brewing the beer on the same land. There's a play area for kids and usually a food truck on weekends. It's the kind of slow afternoon that does what we do — just with a different view.

Mile One Eating House

The post-hike burger benchmark. Local BC ingredients, including Pemberton potatoes — which are famously good for soil reasons we won't bore you with. The honest answer when you want a real meal.

Blackbird Bakery

In the old train station area. The croissants are gone by 10 AM. Go early or accept a sandwich.

Pemberton Brewing Co.

The town's other brewery. Worth a stop if you're a beer person. If you have to choose, The Beer Farmers wins.

Farms worth the stop

North Arm Farm

U-pick berries in summer, pumpkins in fall, and a farm-gate shop that's worth the drive on its own. If you want to bring honey or jam back to the cabin, this is where.

PART FIVE

The quieter hikes

For when you've already heard about Joffre.

Rainbow Falls (Pemberton)

A short, moderate 2.2 km loop. Spectacular in May and June when the snowmelt is at its peak. Easier than it sounds and prettier than it photographs.

Goat Lookout (Birkenhead Lake)

A steep 1 km lung-buster from the Birkenhead campground. Twenty hard minutes up, twenty proud minutes at the top, twenty easier minutes back down. High reward for short effort.

Seton Lake & the Kekuli Trail

Further out, toward Lillooet — a longer drive than the others, but worth the road trip on a good-weather day. The Kekuli (Pit House) Interpretive Trail offers a window into the St'át'imc Nation's history with emerald-green Seton Lake as the backdrop. Read it for what it is — a place, not a viewpoint.

PART SIX

Whistler, if you must

Fifty-five minutes south. The opposite of here, on purpose.

You'll have heard about Whistler before you got here. It's a fine day trip — the Peak-to-Peak Gondola is genuinely impressive, the shopping is what it is, and the dinner options scale with the price tag.

Our suggestion: go for the morning. Ride the gondola, walk the village, eat something. Then come back to Birken before the sun sets. The contrast is the point.

Forty-five minutes from Whistler is a fact. A different planet is the feeling.

PART SEVEN

Winter at Birken

The lake freezes. The forest goes quiet. The cabins get even better.

Most people meet Birken in summer. The ones who come back in winter never go back to summer. The lake holds still under a layer of snow, the dock disappears, and the corridor empties out almost completely. Woodsmoke does a lot of the work in winter — it's the smell, the sight from the porch, and the reason your cabin feels the way it does at 4 PM when it's already dark.

The transition zone we sit in means we get more snow than Whistler does — significantly more. The light changes early. Bring layers, bring proper boots, and bring nothing that needs Wi-Fi.

At the resort

The lake in winter

Gates Lake freezes over by January in most years, and stays frozen well into March. Once it's safely set, the lake becomes a wide, quiet plain — for snowshoeing, cross-country skiing, or just walking out and standing in the middle of nowhere. Conditions vary year to year; the hosts will tell you when it's good and when to stay on the shore.

Stargazing

The corridor has some of the darkest skies in southern BC. On a clear winter night the Milky Way is plainly visible from the dock. Stand outside long enough and you'll see why this place felt like a different planet to begin with.

Around the cabin

The fire pits stay lit. The kitchens stay warm. Most cabins have wood stoves and the kind of insulation a century of refinement quietly delivers. A winter week here is about doing very little, very deliberately — books, slow meals, long walks, hot drinks, and the kind of sleep you forgot was possible.

Snowshoeing & cross-country

Quiet sport. Right outside the door.

The Birken-area trail network turns into snowshoeing terrain from December through March. The flat trails around Birkenhead Lake become easy nordic routes, and the old logging roads north of D'Arcy are excellent for cross-country skiing on a sunny day.

We can lend basic snowshoes for use on the property. For real cross-country or longer routes, the closest rental shops are in Pemberton or Whistler — Pemberton is closer and quieter.

Backcountry skiing & touring

World-class terrain. A serious sport.

The Sea-to-Sky corridor is one of the best backcountry ski-touring regions on the continent. The terrain around us — Tenquille, Marriott Basin, the Joffre area — draws serious tourers from across the world.

GOOD TO KNOW

This is real backcountry. It requires avalanche safety training (AST 1 minimum), a beacon-shovel-probe kit, and a partner who knows what they're doing. If you're not already a tourer with the kit, we strongly recommend booking with a certified guide service in Pemberton or Whistler. We can point you to operators we trust.

Whistler-Blackcomb · the resort day

55 minutes south. The gondolas. The lift-served terrain. The opposite of here, in the best way.

If you want lift-served skiing and snowboarding with no logistics, Whistler-Blackcomb is fifty-five minutes down the highway. World-class terrain, every level catered for, and a village that knows exactly what it is.

The play here is the same as in summer: drive in for the morning, ride for the day, drive back before dinner. The fire will be waiting.

Pemberton in winter

Nordic skiing

The Pemberton area has groomed cross-country trails near Mount Currie, and the valley flatlands give you the kind of long, slow ski you can't get on a busy resort. Best on a clear, cold morning.

Snowmobiling

The area is known for sled access into vast alpine terrain. Multiple operators in Pemberton run guided tours for guests of all experience levels — a half-day or full-day option, ranging from gentle valley rides to advanced powder runs in the high country. Worth asking the front desk for the current operator we recommend.

Ice fishing · Anderson Lake

Anderson Lake freezes hard most winters, and locals fish it for Dolly Varden and Bull Trout from the ice. If you're curious and reasonably equipped, it's a memorable cold-weather morning. Check current conditions and licensing before you go.

Getting here in winter

The road is doable. It just needs respect.

Highway 99 from Vancouver is well-maintained and beautiful in winter, but it is mountain driving. Winter tires are required by law on the corridor from October through April, and we mean actually winter — not all-seasons. Drive in daylight when you can. Carry chains if you're nervous, and a blanket either way.

GOOD TO KNOW

If a winter storm is forecast on your travel day, check DriveBC before you leave. The road is rarely closed for long, but a few hours of patience beats the alternative. Reach out to the resort — we'll tell you what we're seeing here.

Practical notes

The stuff worth knowing before you leave the cabin.

Cell service

Spotty north of Pemberton. Effectively gone past D'Arcy. Download your maps before you head out — Google Maps, AllTrails, whatever you use. The resort has Starlink for when you're back.

Groceries & supplies

The Birken Lakeside General Store covers the basics — coffee, snacks, a few cabin essentials, and the kind of artisan goods worth taking home. For a full grocery run, your best bet is Mile One Market or Pemberton Valley Supermarket on the way in. Both are right on Highway 99.

Climate

Drier and hotter than Whistler in summer. Significantly more snow in winter. We sit in a transition zone, and the weather can shift fast. Pack layers always.

Wildlife

Bear country. No food in cabins overnight, no garbage on porches, and stay alert on the trails after dusk. The hosts will give you a quick brief at check-in and we'll always answer questions.

Pets

Dogs are welcome at Birken. Bring the leash for the corridor walks (cougars and wildlife share the trails) and the towel for the dock. There's a small pet fee per night.

A CLOSING NOTE

Ask us anything

This guide is what we'd tell a friend over coffee on the porch — but it's not a substitute for the porch. If you want to know what the trail conditions are like today, where the berries are in season, or just whether the Grille is open this weekend, ask the host on duty.

The lake does most of the selling. We do the rest.

QUESTIONS BEFORE YOU ARRIVE?

WE'RE HERE.

If anything in this guide raises a question — about your cabin, the drive, the weather, what to do with the kids on a rainy afternoon — just ask. The fastest way to reach us is email, or the phone if it's urgent.

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See you at the dock.

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